TOWN OF THUNDERBOLT
REGULAR MONTHLY MEETING
WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 10, 2022
6:00 PM
REVISED

AGENDA HEARING

Public has three minutes per person to ask questions or comment on any agenda item.

Jan Yarbrough, 24 Bonaventure Rd., requested Mayor and Council respond to the request from over 30 people asking them to rescind the rezoning of five properties on River Dr. Ms. Yarbrough asked why did the Town rezone and not the owners? Town Attorney Barrow stated staff saw a gap in the River Drive District and brought this to Council's attention. She asked if the property owners were notified before going to Planning & Zoning. They were notified during the process. She asked why include Center Street? Town Attorney Barrow stated for continuity. Ms. Yarbrough asked why did staff and Council not follow the ordinance of an application. Town Attorney Barrow explained the town does not have to do an application. The Council's motion was the application. Ms. Yarbrough stated Council Member Crenshaw did not reveal financials. Town Attorney Barrow explained that is true and can be rectified now but everyone on Council was aware he owned two of the parcels. Ms. Yarbrough read off a list of items not met: the requirements for a text amendment was not met. A map was not attached to the application. Public notices were not verified. Ad was in the newspaper did not have the names of the property. Letter did not go out. A report was not submitted to Council from Planning and Zoning. Town Administrator Milie stopped Ms. Yarbrough as stated it would be easier one question at a time. Town Attorney Barrow explained the meeting minutes was the report. He then explained the process staff and Council followed. He explained staff made an error in the newspaper ad for the March Council Meeting. The petition was moved to the April Meeting. The newspaper made an error with the April ad and the petition had to be moved to the May meeting. Letters were mailed out before each meeting. The PIN numbers and addresses were on the letters. As for rescinding the rezoning, Mayor and Council are the ones to make that decision.

Town Administrator Milie stated as staff had explained several times before in the previous meetings Center Street was included to create a contiguous line. We corrected the spot zoning that was created when River Drive and Victory Drive Districts were created.

Council Member Lavin spoke about not agreeing with the decision and had voted against the rezoning.

Geneva Golden, 3126 Gilbert St., asked who or what is considered the town? Town Attorney Barrow explained the town in his response was Mayor and Council.

Mayor Williams closed the hearing at 6:30 pm

MILLAGE RATE PUBLIC HEARING

Public has three minutes per person to ask questions or comment on millage rate.

Mayor Williams opened the millage public hearing at 6:30 pm. Town Administrator Milie stated this is the 3rd meeting in compliance with the state law. The current millage is 6.132. Staff recommendation was to maintain the same millage rate. This is considered an increase. Holding at the current millage rate, instead of rolling back, will assist in maintaining the current budget.

Beth Goette, 3006 Leonard St, asked why is the percentage 11.7% at the bottom so high. Town Administrator Milie stated he was not sure. He did not believe the number was wrong. He believed if we adopt the complete rollback, it would be a 11.7% difference to holding the current rate. Council Member Drohan explained the County values the property. Council Member Drohan asked Town Administrator Milie the difference in the budget holding at the current millage. Town Administrator Milie stated it is an approximate $75,000 added to the budget. Council Member Crenshaw asked Town Attorney Barrow to explain Stevens-Day Bill. Town Attorney Barrow explained on your primary home the assessed value will stay at the price of your home when you completed the filing with the County until selling or pass to heirs.

Mayor Williams closed the hearing at 6:45 pm

REGULAR MEETING

1. **Call to order**

Mayor Williams called the regular meeting to order at 6:45 pm.

2. **Roll Call by Presiding Officer with Invocation, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance**

Those in attendance were Mayor Dana Williams and Council Members: Dave Crenshaw, Larry Ward, Ed Drohan, James Lavin, and Brooks Barbaree. Council Member Bethany Skipper-Greer was virtual. Staff in attendance were: Town Administrator, Bob Milie; Town Attorney, Charlie Barrow; Town Clerk, Deatre Denion; Accts Payable/Utiltiy Manager, Katina Spaulding, Police Chief, Sean Clayton; Fire Chief, Andrew Bateman and Customer Service Clerk, Renee Holmes.

3. **Approval of Meeting Agenda**

Mayor Williams asked for a motion to approve the agenda. **Council Member Ward made the motion to approve with a second from Council Member Drohan. The motion passed unanimously.**

4. **Approval of Minutes from Previous Meeting**:
   Minutes of July 13, 2022

Mayor Williams asked for a motion to approve the July 13th meeting minutes. **Council Member Ward made the motion to approve with a second from Council Member Drohan. The motion passed unanimously.**

5. **Presentations:**

   a) Atlantic Waste

Mallory Boyd, Atlantic Waste, explained there has been a recent change in drivers. To keep the integrity of the collections, on Monday for recycling the truck will stop and check in with Town Hall. They will provide a list of the containers not dumped due to contamination and to make sure no containers were missed. They will do the same with Trash and Yard waste on Tuesday. Tags will be placed for violations of the policy. Mayor Williams asked if glass was now ok. Ms. Boyd stated no glass. They will only pick up 4 X 4 piles of yard waste. If we do not set a limitation, we will not complete services in a day. They do pick up bulk items such as grills, stoves and old furniture; but cannot pick up refrigerators. Council Member Drohan asked if they will dump the old green bins for yard waste. Ms. Boyd

stated they prefer 4 X 4 pile and yard waste bags. Mayor Williams asked Ms. Boyd to explain about contamination for recycling. She explained it only takes 15% or 20% contamination to prevent recycling the truck. She explained general trash is the biggest issue. Council Member Ward asked this information to be in the newsletter.

b) Finance Report:

Shannon Brett, CPA firm, provided an overview. Everything has been updated through July. The Town has spent 2.6 million, 51% of the budget.

6. **Public Hearing for Planning and Zoning**

a. **Petitioner:** Nona & Ray Darley
Request: Property Line Adjustment
Parcel Involved: 3-0009-01-030 and 3-0009-01-031
Location: 24 & 22C Brightwater Dr.
P & Z unanimously approved the petition

Clerk of Council Denion explained the Darleys sold the adjacent property to a relative and wish to provide a little more yard. This was agreed upon in writing at the sell. Mayor Williams asked for a motion. **Council Member Drohan made the motion to approve the petition with a second from Council Member Ward. The motion passed unanimously.**

b. **Petitioner**: Kay McCafferty
Request: Setback Variance
Parcel Involved: 3-0005-01-014
Location: 3227 Bannon Dr.
P & Z unanimously approved the petition

Petitioner, Kay McCafferty, explained they need variance to build a carport. **Council Member Barbaree made the motion to approve the petition with a second from Council Member Drohan.** Council Member Drohan explained he was at the P & Z meeting and stated Ms. McCafferty did a great job illustrating the request for the board to understand. This petition will provide a continuity of the block. **The motion passed unanimously.**

Petitioner: 209 Bonaventure Rd LLC
Request: Variance for Parking and Number of Units
Parcel Involved: 3-0001-02-010
Location: 209 Bonaventure Rd.
P & Z unanimously denied the petition

Clerk of Council Denion explained the request is a variance to allow up to 96 units over 63 units that are allowed. They also are requesting a reduction in the number of parking spaces. Staff did not recommend approval due to putting the town to its sewer capacity limits. P & Z unanimously denied the petition. **Council Member Drohan made the motion to deny with a second from Council Member Crenshaw.** Council Member Drohan stated this petition is what instigated a discussion for later on in the meeting on infrastructure. **The motion passed unanimously.**

7. **Consent Agenda:**

a) Approval of Staff Modifications
b) Approval of the Police Department Vehicle Purchase

Council Member Ward made the motion to approve the Consent Agenda with a second by Council Member Drohan. The motion passed unanimously.

8. **Discussion Agenda:**

a) Approval of the Milage Rate

Town Administrator Milie stated there have been three meetings. Staff recommendation was to adopt the maintenance of 6.132. He clarified the net increase of 11.7 % is the difference of the roll back to the proposed millage. **Council Member Crenshaw made the motion to approve staff recommendation with a second from Council Member Ward. The motion passed unanimously.** Council Member Barbaree stated if you look at other communities there is a large increase in the net increase.

b) Discussion and Approval of the Disaster Monitoring Contract

Town Administrator Milie stated there were four bids and they all met requirements. After scoring the bids, they all were equal so they looked at the financials. Staff recommends Witt O'Brian since they came in a little less and are our current monitor. **Council Member Crenshaw made the motion to approve the recommendation with a second from Council Member Ward. The motion passed unanimously.**

c) Approval of Planning and Zoning Commissioner Appointments

Mayor Williams stated the recommendation for Planning and Zoning appointments are Richard Schleicher, Krista Kilburn and Sean Compton. **Council Member Crenshaw made the motion to approve the appointments with a second by Council Member Drohan. The motion passed unanimously.**

~~d) Approval of Savannah Simply Marketing Contract for 2023 Blessing of the Fleet~~ removed until Sept.

9. **Town Administrator Report:** Town Administrator, Bob Milie
   a) AARP Certification
   b) Website and STR Update
   c) Grass Cutting Update

Town Administrator Milie stated the STR host compliance with Granicus should start September 8. The website is in collection of content phase.

Town Administrator Milie explained AARP recognized Town of Thunderbolt as an age friendly community. He presented the certification to Mayor and Council.

10. **Department Report** – Written Reports Submitted

by: Police / Municipal Court / Neighborhood Watch – Sean Clayton, Chief of Police

Town Administrator Milie explained there was a robbery of a very violent nature. The police were able to arrest a suspect by noon the next day. Mayor Williams stated the suspects from the shooting that happened several weeks ago were apprehended. The stolen trailer was recovered. Council Member Skipper-Greer asked about the speed cameras on Whatley. Chief Clayton stated they are working and run from 6:45 am to 7:45 am then from 2 pm to 3 pm.

Fire –Fire Chief, Andrew Bateman

Chief Bateman stated they are currently shorthanded. He recognized Josh Moeller for stepping up during this time. Council Member Drohan asked how construction is going at the Firehouse. Chief Bateman stated everything is framed out.

Public Works Department – Oscar Crosby, Public Works Manager

Council Member Brooks pointed out the landscaping the staff have been working on at Thompson Park and other locations.

11. **Legal Report – Town Attorney**

a) Rezoning of five properties to River Drive District

12. **Mayor and Council –**

a) Thunderbolt Development and Resource Utilization Project – Council Member Drohan
See notes

The Changing Face of Thunderbolt

To address the structural and infrastructure needs of our town, anticipating future needs is central to that task. The data that drive these decisions are often a function of longer-term trends that reflect the transformational capacity of cultural factors such as education, lifestyle priorities as well as the financial realities of living in a part of the world where it seems like everyone wants to live.

The following are sets of comparative and current data reflecting the evolving trends that impact the Town Thunderbolt and necessarily drive the choices that we will need to make as a community in both the near and long-term.

Thunderbolt, GA Demographic Data

Census Year	2010	2020	
Population	2668	2638	
Factors			
Mean Age	39.2	49.8	
Under 17	17.6	14.4	(1-19)
18-24	9.2%	7.0	(20-24)
25-44	28.1%	35.8%	
45-64	23.8	27.6	
65+	21.2	26.4	

The Population of Thunderbolt is relatively steady over the past 15 years and has become notably older over the past decade.

Households	1088	1091
Average Household Size	2.19	2.01
Median Income	$45,327	$60,819 (2019)

The number of households are relatively even over the past decade though household size has dropped by about 20%.

Number of Residences	1382
Single Units	54%
Occupied	91%
Owner Occupied	59%
Rental	41%

Currently, the residences in Thunderbolt are evenly split between single units and condominiums and apartments.

Property values are about 20% higher than the Savannah area and 25% higher than the State of Georgia.

Education Attained	Percentage	
	2010	2020
	(Unavailable)	
Less Than 9th Grade		3.33%
9th to 12th Grade		10.09%
High School Graduate		23.37%
Some College		17.91%
Associates Degree		5.17%
Bachelor's Degree		20.33%
Graduate Degree		19.80%

The educational attainment of the citizens of Thunderbolt is about 25% higher than the Savannah area and the State of Georgia.

Per capita income is about 20% higher than the Savannah area and the State of Georgia.

Thunderbolt continues to be a consistently diversified community over the past 10 years.

About 60% of the population self-describe as White Collar or Professional.

SUMMARY

1- The Population of Thunderbolt is relatively steady over the past 15 years and has become notably older over the past decade.

2- The number of households are relatively even over the past decade and the household size has dropped by about 20%.

3- Currently, the residences in Thunderbolt are fairly evenly split between single units and condominiums and apartments.

Property values are about 20% higher than the Savannah area and 25% higher than the State of Georgia.

4- The educational attainment of the citizens of Thunderbolt is about 25% higher than the Savannah area and the State of Georgia.

Per capita income is about 20% higher than the Savannah area and the State of Georgia.

Thunderbolt continues to be a consistently diversified community over the past 10 years.

About 60% of the population self-describe as White Collar/Professional.

In other words, our citizens are a diversified group of older, generally better educated individuals living in smaller family units.

More of our citizens self-identify as white-collar and professional.

The relatively higher property values likely reflect the desirability of living in Thunderbolt suggesting future pressures on the development of available properties that exist here.

In addition to these data, many people have commented on how Thunderbolt is becoming a prime area for first-time homebuyers, bringing in younger couples and growing families.

All of these factors impact the evolving "Face of Thunderbolt" and as such directly impact the decisions that we need to make as a town for our mutual long-term welfare.

The recent requests for variances on property development have highlighted a notable problem with regards to the upper limits of sewer resources allowed us by our contract with the City of Savannah and the clear messages from them that those limits are unlikely to be increased. Though these issues have been focused upon the 7-acre tract along Bonaventure Avenue, I believe that this is in fact a town wide issue and deserves to be addressed by then Council in the near term.

In pursuit of that goal, I have asked our folks in administration to create a listing of undeveloped/underdeveloped properties in Thunderbolt so that we can then approach the likely future demand of development in Thunderbolt relative to the realities of our limited capacities in a manner that is responsible to our citizens and equally respects the rights of all property owners in Thunderbolt.

To that end, I have formulated some "Development Zones" that I think reasonably identifies the category and location of properties whose development will likely place demands on our infrastructure. Furthermore, I have taken a stab at identifying "Development Factors" that should reasonably be assessed for each of these categories.

The goal of course would be to operationalize a clear understanding of the nature and degree of future development demands and to assess those alongside the realities of our limited infrastructure capacities.

Please review the following information and feel free to help me create a more thorough list of Development Zones and Development Factors as well as recommending additional factors relative to this issue that you believe are important.

Development Zones

River Drive

Victory Drive

Shell Road Corridor

Bonaventure Ave

Downing Ave

Individual Lots (Undeveloped)

Blighted Properties

Development Factors

Density (Per Current Code)

Water Usage/ Density Unit

Sewer Usage/ Density Unit

Drainage Requirements

Improvement Requirements

Water Infrastructure

Sewer Infrastructure

Drainage Infrastructure

Roadway/ Transportation Infrastructure

Council Member Lavin asked about sewer capacity. Town Administrator Milie stated the Town uses 320,000 a day with 500,0000 allowed gallons.

b) Thunderbolt Museum Report

Anna Maria Thomas stated there will not be a spaghetti dinner this year. There will be multi-vendor sale September 24th. They are looking for donations. The museum has had some updates with a new fire wheel.

Mayor Williams asked for a motion to adjourn into executive session. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second from Council Member Crenshaw. The motion passed unanimously.**

13. **Executive Session-** Mayor requests a motion and a second to recess into executive session for the purpose of Legal, Real Estate and/or Personnel matters.

Mayor Williams asked for a motion to return to regular meeting. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second from Council Member Crenshaw. The motion passed unanimously.**

Mayor Williams asked for a motion to adjourn. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second from Council Member Crenshaw.** Town Administrator Milie stated for the record before they adjourn, Council supports the Police Chief and his department. **The motion passed unanimously.**

14. **Adjournment:**

The meeting adjourned at 8:06 pm.

Mayor, Dana Williams

Clerk of Council, Deatre N. Denion